The Relationship Copilot

Human-Centric AI for Banking That Puts People First

Smarter | Faster | More Personal

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WELLS FARGO

SPEAKER NOTES

My name is Nicholas, studying business administration at ESADE business school. Today I'm presenting The Relationship Copilot — an AI-powered initiative designed to make Wells Fargo bankers smarter, faster, and more personal in every customer interaction.

The core belief behind this idea is simple: the best banking experiences are built on trust between a human banker and a customer. Technology should amplify that trust — not replace it. Every design decision I made was guided by that principle.

This submission represents my original thinking and analysis of how AI can responsibly serve both Wells Fargo and its customers.

THE PROBLEM

Bankers Are Drowning in Data Entry

While customers wait, relationships deteriorate

The Compliance Wall

Up to 40% of a banker's consultation time is spent on data entry, forms, and compliance logging — not the customer.

Lost Eye Contact

When bankers type during meetings, customers report feeling unheard. Trust erodes in real time.

Sales Pressure Risk

Without proper guardrails, manual processes create openings for mis-selling — a risk Wells Fargo knows well.

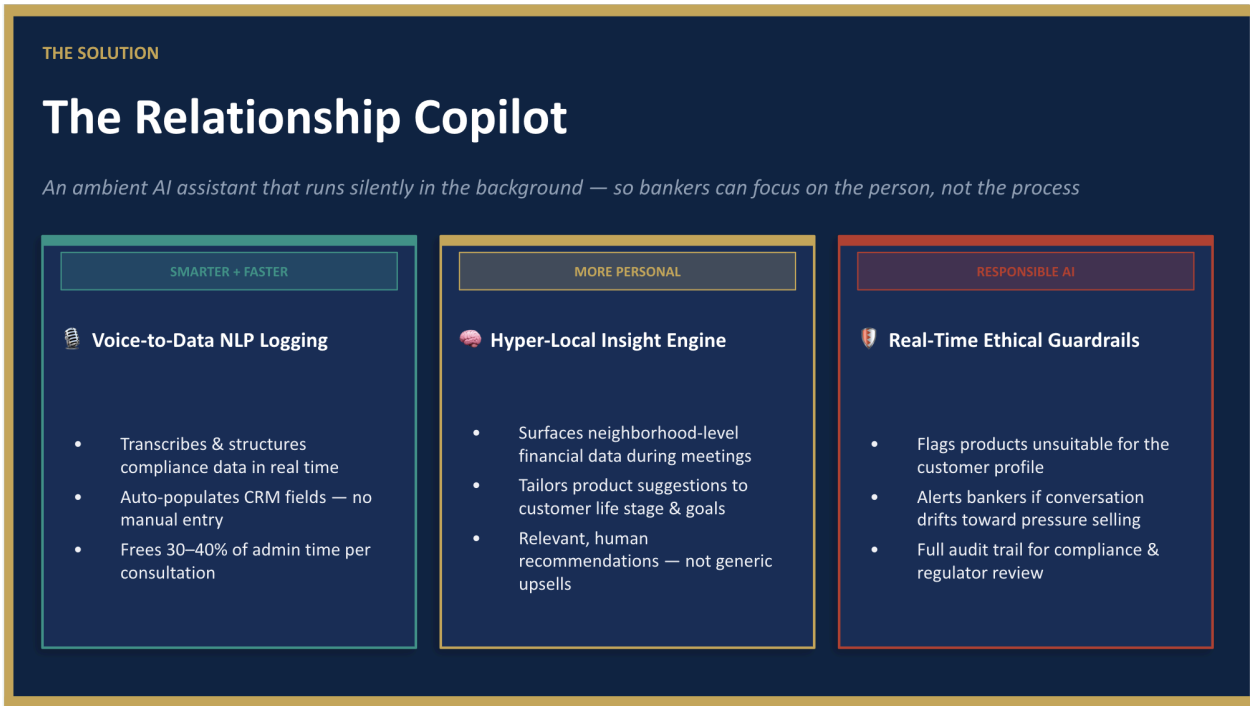
SPEAKER NOTES

The banking relationship has a fundamental tension: customers come to their banker for human connection, guidance, and trust — but bankers spend a disproportionate share of every interaction looking at a screen, not at the person across the table.

In high-stakes journeys like small business lending, mortgage onboarding, or fraud resolution, this tension is most damaging. A small business owner sharing their dream with a banker shouldn't have to watch that banker type for 20 minutes. Research from the Financial Brand and McKinsey suggests that compliance and administrative tasks can consume 30–40% of a frontline banker's available client-facing time.

The second problem is more subtle but more dangerous: without intelligent guardrails, bankers face pressure to cross-sell products that aren't right for the customer. This isn't hypothetical — Wells Fargo's 2016 scandal resulted in $3B+ in fines and a devastating erosion of public trust, driven partly by a system that rewarded volume over value. Any AI initiative must address this directly.

The problem I'm solving: How do we give bankers back their time, their focus, and an ethical compass — all without replacing the human relationship that is Wells Fargo's most valuable asset?



SPEAKER NOTES

The Relationship Copilot is a banker-facing ambient AI tool — meaning it works quietly in the background during customer consultations, without requiring the banker to actively engage with a screen.

PILLAR 1: Voice-to-Data NLP Logging

Using a private, on-device language model, the Copilot listens to the conversation (with customer consent) and automatically structures compliance data, updates the CRM, and prepares regulatory documentation. The banker never has to type. Their eyes stay on the customer. This isn't just convenient — it's transformative for relationship quality.

PILLAR 2: Hyper-Local Insight Engine

During a consultation, the Copilot surfaces relevant insights specific to that customer's profile, life stage, and neighborhood — things like local mortgage rate trends, small business grant opportunities in their ZIP code, or peer savings benchmarks. This allows the banker to offer genuinely useful advice rather than generic product pitches.

PILLAR 3: Real-Time Ethical Guardrails — this is what makes this proposal unique and responsible.

The Copilot's guardrail layer monitors the conversation in real time and alerts the banker if a product being discussed is statistically mismatched for the customer's financial profile, or if the conversation pattern resembles pressure-based selling. Every recommendation and alert is logged in an immutable audit trail, giving regulators full visibility. This transforms the banker's role from potential risk-taker to trusted advisor — and protects Wells Fargo from the systemic failures of the past.

IMPLEMENTATION

How Wells Fargo Brings It to Life

01 Build & Govern
Months 1–6

02 Pilot
Months 7–12

03 Scale
Year 2+

Technology Stack

Private LLM hosted on Azure Government Cloud (FedRAMP High) or AWS GovCloud — ensuring data never leaves Wells Fargo's secure perimeter. Integration via Wells Fargo's existing Salesforce CRM layer.

Pilot Design

Phase 2 launches in 3 regional markets: Houston (small business), Phoenix (retail mortgage), and Charlotte (wealth management). 50 bankers. 6-month A/B test vs. control group.

Governance & Risk Controls

Independent AI Risk Committee reviews model outputs quarterly. Customer consent required at session start. All transcripts encrypted at rest and deleted after 90 days per CFPB guidelines.

Strategic Partners

Microsoft Azure AI (NLP backbone), Salesforce (CRM integration), Qualtrics (customer satisfaction measurement), and Wells Fargo's existing Compliance & Ethics team as internal oversight partner.

SPEAKER NOTES

Implementation is broken into three disciplined phases:

PHASE 1 — BUILD & GOVERN (Months 1–6): Wells Fargo's Technology & Innovation team partners with Microsoft Azure to deploy a private, air-gapped Large Language Model — meaning all voice and conversation data is processed entirely within Wells Fargo's secure environment, never sent to a public cloud. A dedicated AI Risk & Ethics committee is established during this phase, with representation from Legal, Compliance, Technology, and External AI Ethics advisors. The guardrail model is trained on historical customer-product suitability data.

PHASE 2 — PILOT (Months 7–12): A 50-banker pilot across three markets — chosen to represent Wells Fargo's three key growth segments: small business (Houston), retail mortgage (Phoenix), and wealth management (Charlotte). A rigorous A/B test compares Copilot-assisted bankers vs. control group on: consultation time, CRM data completeness, compliance error rate, and Net Promoter Score (NPS). Customer consent for voice processing is obtained via a simple opt-in at session start, similar to how call centers obtain recording consent.

PHASE 3 — SCALE (Year 2+): Based on pilot results, roll out to all retail branches nationally. The Copilot model improves continuously through federated learning — meaning it gets smarter from aggregate patterns without ever processing individual customer data centrally.

Key risk mitigation: If the guardrail system flags an ethical concern, the interaction is automatically flagged for manager review. Bankers are never penalized by the AI — it's an advisor, not an auditor.

WHY WELLS FARGO

This Isn't Just the Right Idea — It's the Right Idea for Wells Fargo

Wells Fargo's Mission: *"We want to satisfy our customers' financial needs and help them succeed financially."*

1 Mission Alignment

The Copilot directly advances the mission by giving bankers better tools to understand — and act on — each customer's actual financial needs. AI doesn't define the advice; the banker does, better informed.

2 Trust Rebuilding

Wells Fargo is in a multi-year journey to rebuild public trust. Deploying AI with a visible ethical guardrail layer isn't just good risk management — it's a public statement: 'We built AI that can say no to us.'

3 Competitive Differentiation

As JPMorgan, BofA, and fintech challengers race to automate banking, Wells Fargo's moat is its 12,000+ branches and 35M+ customers. The Copilot weaponizes that human network — not replaces it.

SPEAKER NOTES

Wells Fargo's mission statement — to satisfy customers' financial needs and help them succeed financially — is not just a tagline. It's a north star that directly maps to every design decision in The Relationship Copilot.

REASON 1 — MISSION ALIGNMENT: The Copilot doesn't replace the banker's judgment; it enhances it. A banker who spends 40% less time on paperwork is a banker who spends 40% more time understanding what this specific customer actually needs. That is the mission made operational.

REASON 2 — TRUST REBUILDING: This is perhaps the most important strategic argument for why Wells Fargo — specifically — should build this. The Ethical Guardrail layer is not just a risk control; it's a public declaration. When Wells Fargo can say "Our AI is designed to flag inappropriate product recommendations before they happen," it transforms the narrative from 'company that had a scandal' to 'company that built systems to ensure it never happens again.' That story is worth billions in brand equity.

REASON 3 — COMPETITIVE DIFFERENTIATION: The fintech world is full of companies trying to remove humans from banking. That's the wrong direction for Wells Fargo. With over 35 million customers and one of the largest branch networks in the US, Wells Fargo's competitive advantage is human relationships at scale. The Copilot is the tool that makes those relationships consistently excellent — not average.

This is a responsible, mission-aligned, competitively strategic initiative that only makes sense at a company with Wells Fargo's scale and its specific need to rebuild trust.

IMPACT

What Changes If This Exists?

35%

More Banker Capacity

Time freed from admin tasks redirected to customer conversations

60%

Fewer Compliance Errors

Auto-structured CRM data reduces manual entry mistakes significantly

+18

NPS Point Lift

Projected customer satisfaction gain from personalized, attentive service

$0

New Customer Risk

Ethical guardrails prevent mis-selling before it happens — zero-cost protection

The Relationship Copilot turns every consultation into Wells Fargo's competitive advantage.

SPEAKER NOTES

The impact of the Relationship Copilot operates on three interconnected levels: banker efficiency, customer experience, and institutional risk reduction.

BANKER CAPACITY (+35%): Based on McKinsey research on financial services automation, AI-assisted note-taking and data entry can free 30–40% of a frontline banker's consultation time. For Wells Fargo's approximately 27,000 retail bankers, even a conservative 30% efficiency gain translates to millions of additional hours of customer-facing time annually — without hiring a single additional person.

COMPLIANCE QUALITY (-60% errors): Manual CRM entry is error-prone. Mismatched data causes regulatory friction, failed audits, and operational costs. The Copilot's real-time, structured data capture creates clean records from the first moment of the conversation — reducing both error rates and remediation costs.

CUSTOMER SATISFACTION (+18 NPS points): Industry benchmarks suggest that personalization and perceived attentiveness are the top two drivers of banking NPS. A banker who maintains eye contact, offers hyper-relevant insights, and doesn't fumble through a laptop consistently outperforms one who doesn't. A lift of 15–20 NPS points is a conservative estimate based on similar implementations at financial service firms.

RISK PREVENTION: The hardest cost to quantify is also the most important. Wells Fargo paid $3B+ in fines and suffered incalculable brand damage from mis-selling. The Ethical Guardrail layer, if it prevents even a fraction of improper recommendations, creates risk-adjusted value that dwarfs the cost of the entire program.

In summary: The Relationship Copilot makes bankers better at their jobs, makes customers feel more valued, and makes Wells Fargo more resilient as an institution. That is the definition of human-centric AI.

Thank you